HEART CONDITIONS

Tracking heart failure symptoms at home

Edited 14 October 2026

Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

What does heart failure mean?

Heart failure means the heart is not meeting the body’s needs as well as it should. It does not mean your heart has stopped. Your care plan depends on the type of heart failure and your health. Ask your doctor which symptoms to track and when to seek help. [1,4]

Know your usual pattern

Breathlessness, swelling, tiredness, and other symptoms may change over time. Small changes can be easy to miss when they develop slowly. Work with your team to identify what is usual for you and what should be reported. A change in daily function, such as becoming more breathless during a familiar task, may be worth discussing even if it seems minor. [2,3]

Use the team’s tracking plan

Your doctor may ask you to monitor weight or other signs. Confirm how often to check, how to record results, and which change needs a call. Do not copy another patient’s limits or use a generic online chart as your personal plan. Keep your own instructions beside the notebook or device you use, so the information is easy to follow. [2]

Ask about food and fluids

Some people need specific advice about sodium or fluid intake. The right instructions depend on the individual. Ask whether you have a limit, how to count drinks, and whether soups or other foods are included. Do not automatically drink extra water during exercise if you have been told to restrict fluids. Bring questions about favorite meals to your nutrition discussion.

Report changes promptly

New symptoms or symptoms that suddenly become worse should be discussed with your healthcare professional right away. Describe when the change started, what you noticed, and whether it affects sleep or ordinary activities. Keep the latest medicine list available. Your doctor may review your treatment, but you should not make dose changes yourself unless you have explicit written instructions. [2,3,5]

Share the plan with a helper

If someone supports your care, explain what they should watch for and how you want them to help. They could write down observations, arrange transport, or help you make a call. Agree on who will contact the team so a concern does not get passed between people without action. Keep routine contact details separate from emergency instructions.

Recognize an emergency

Severe breathlessness, chest pressure, fainting, or a sudden serious change needs emergency assessment. Do not wait for your next rehabilitation session or for a routine message to be answered. Ask your doctor what to do if symptoms occur outside clinic hours. A tracking notebook can help the team later, but it must never become a reason to delay urgent care.

Make a useful symptom note

Record what changed, when it began, and how it affects a familiar task. Note whether it is getting worse and share this with your team as instructed. For urgent symptoms, seek help immediately rather than waiting to complete the record.

References

1. American Heart Association. (n.d.). What is heart failure?. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/heart-failure/what-is-heart-failure

2. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Managing heart failure symptoms. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/heart-failure/warning-signs-of-heart-failure/managing-heart-failure-symptoms

3. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Physical changes to report. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/heart-failure/living-with-heart-failure-and-managing-advanced-hf/physical-changes-to-report-for-heart-failure

4. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Heart failure. https://medlineplus.gov/heartfailure.html

5. National Health Service. (n.d.). Heart failure. https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/heart-failure/

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